UniCircle

UX / User-Centred Product Design Case Study

Report and Evaluation

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Figma: *view prototype*

Developed as part of an undergraduate Human–Computer Interaction (HCI) module.
Newcastle University

PART 1 - REPORT

1. Structure and navigation design

The UniCircle prototype uses a mainly flat navigation structure with a persistent bottom navigation bar on the primary screens *(Figure 1).* The five sections – **Home, Discover, My Schedule, Messages** and **Profile** – are always available and provide clear, predictable access to the core tasks: finding events, planning attendance, coordinating with friends and personalising content. This keeps navigation shallow and aligns with students' existing mental models of social and messaging apps, reducing memory load when moving between activities.

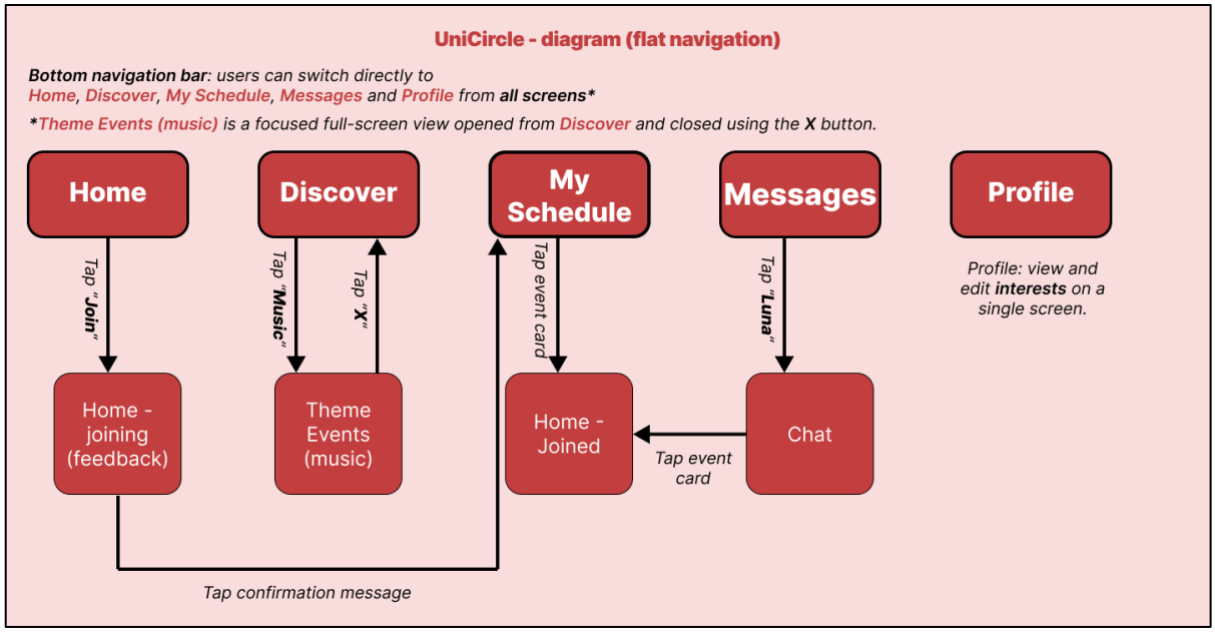


Figure 1: UniCircle navigation diagram showing flat bottom navigation and key task flows.

From the **Home** tab, the main event post appears in the feed with a prominent **"Join +"** button *(Figure 2)*. Selecting this button takes the user to a feedback variant of the Home screen (**"Home – joining (feedback)"**), which overlays a confirmation message: **"Joined – successfully added to My Schedule"**. From there the user can either use the bottom bar or tap the confirmation message itself to move to **My Schedule**. My Schedule lists joined events as cards with clear date, time and location details and a green **"Joined"** pill, supporting planning and providing an overview of upcoming commitments. Selecting an event card returns the user to the original post (**"Home – joined"**), now showing the joined state *(Figure 3)*.

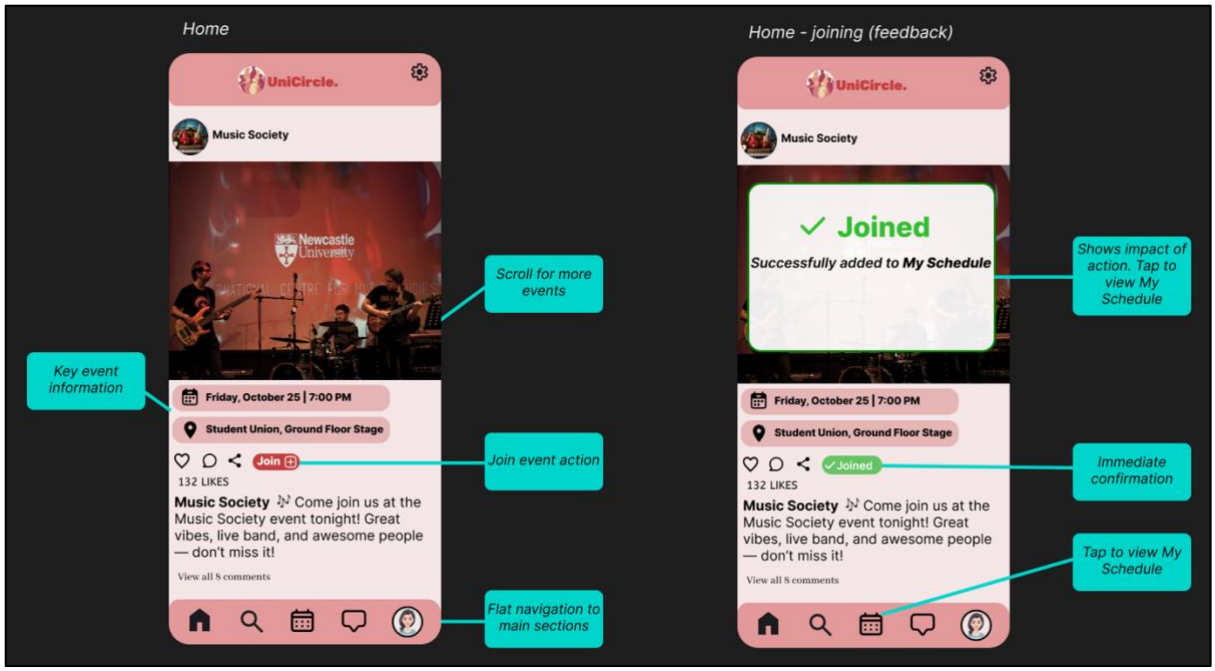


Figure 2: Home screen before joining an event (left) and feedback state after tapping "Join +" (right).

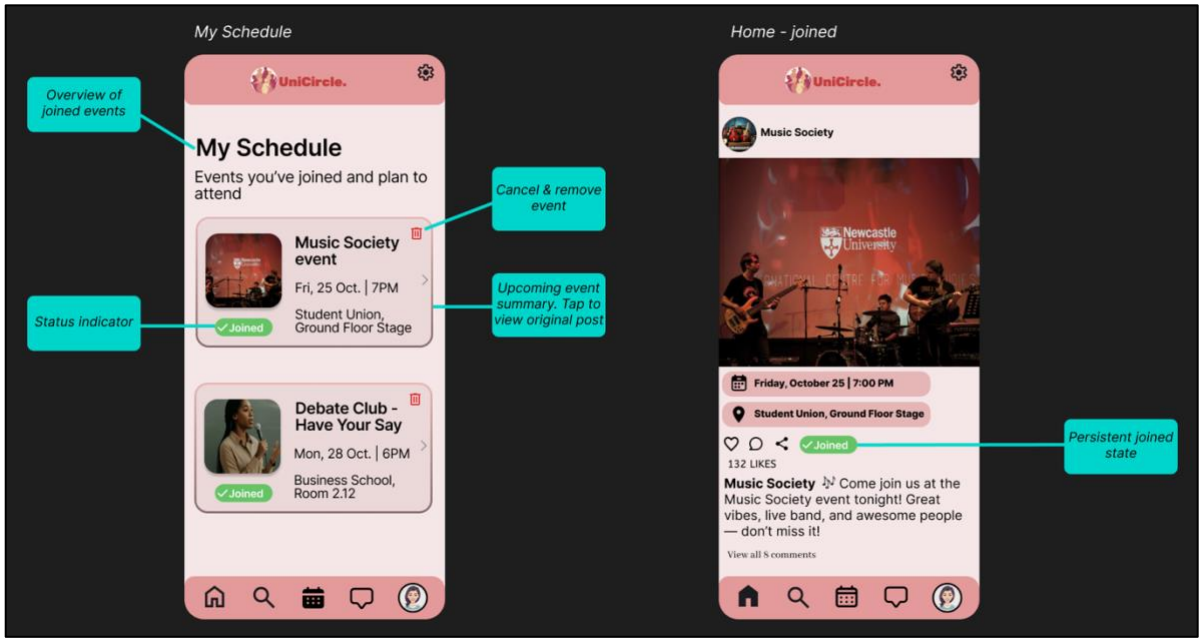


Figure 3: My Schedule listing joined events (left) and the original post showing the joined state (right).

The **Discover** tab supports exploration *(Figure 4)*. It presents trending events and an **"Explore by theme"** area. Selecting the Music theme opens a focused **"Theme Events (music)"** screen that can be swiped for more events and closed with a clear **X**, providing a simple drill-down from the flat structure while keeping the user's place in Discover. This screen intentionally hides the bottom navigation bar to reduce clutter and keep attention on one interest area.

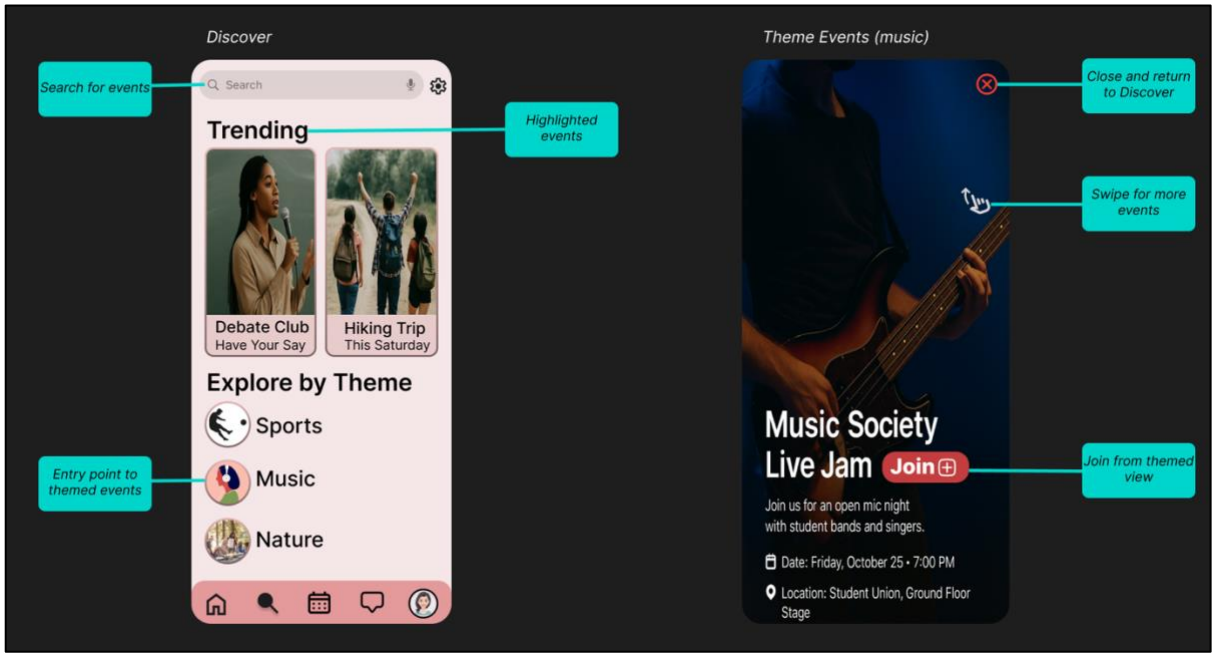


Figure 4: Discover screen with "Explore by theme" (left) and the Theme Events view for Music (right).

The **Messages** tab provides a list of direct messages with online status indicators *(Figure 5)*. Selecting *Luna* opens the **Chat** screen, where the event can be shared as a post within the conversation. Tapping the shared event returns the user to the Home feed, maintaining a consistent link between social coordination and the original event information.

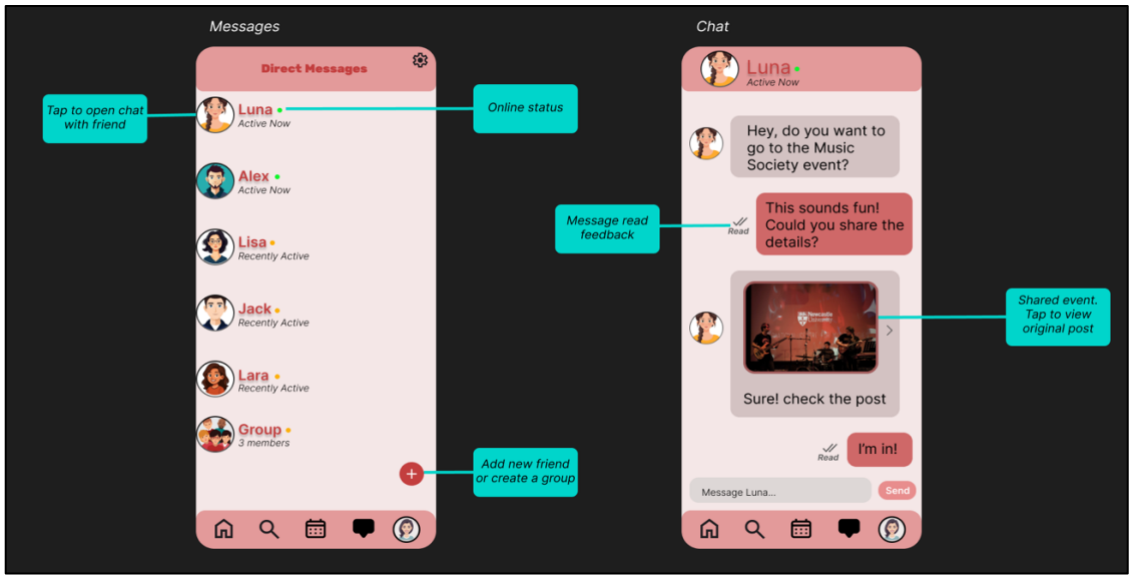


Figure 5: Messages list (left) and chat with a friend, where the event is shared as a post (right).

Finally, the **Profile** tab shows the student's name and degree, and includes toggle chips for interests (e.g. Music, Debate, Hiking). Changes are made directly on this screen, and the subtitle explains that UniCircle will prioritise content that matches these selections *(Figure 6)*. This makes the mapping between preferences and the rest of the app explicit, while keeping navigation simple and consistent.

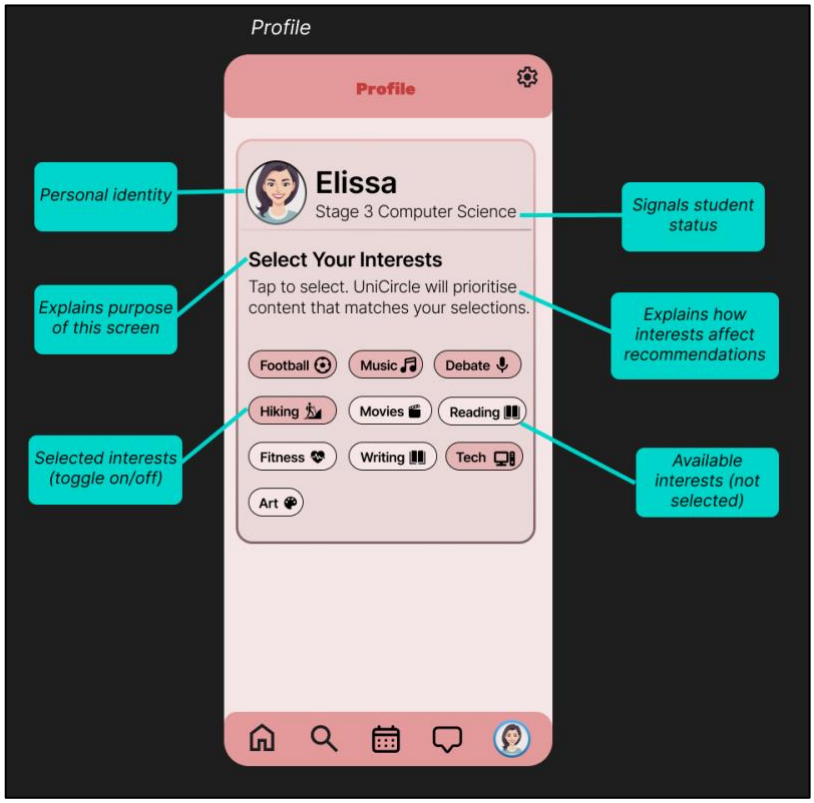


Figure 6: Profile screen showing integrated view and editing of interests using toggle chips to personalise event recommendations.

2. Design explanation

UniCircle is a mobile app concept designed to help first-year students discover on-campus events, decide which ones to join, and attend with friends. An initial survey with 10 students suggested that event discovery, group or community features and matching people based on shared interests would be particularly useful in a social-connection tool *(Figure 7)*. These insights led to three design goals for this prototype: provide simple navigation between discovering events, planning attendance and messaging friends; make the impact of actions such as joining or cancelling an event very clear; and allow students to tailor what they see based on their interests. The annotated screenshots in Figures 2–6 explain how the UniCircle prototype addresses these goals using key HCI concepts.

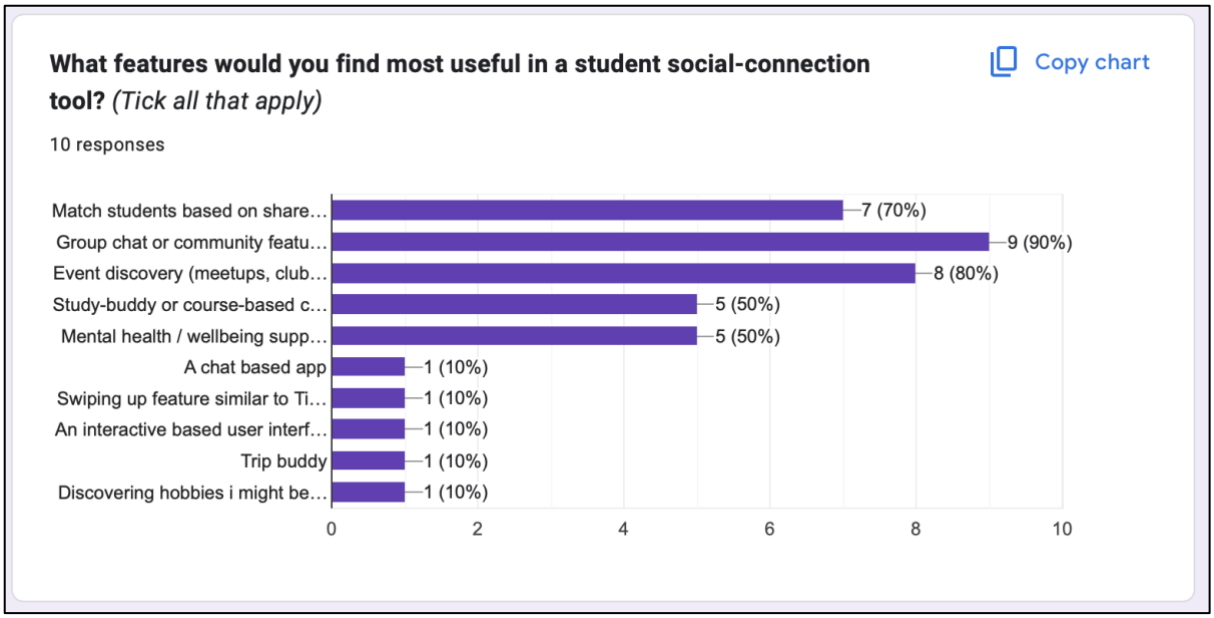


Figure 7: Survey responses (n = 10) showing demand for event discovery, group/community features and matching based on shared interests.

Heading: 1. Clear mental model for the design

Screen shots: *Figures 1, 2, 3*

Description and rationale:

The design reinforces a clear mental model of "find an event – decide to join – see it in My Schedule – coordinate with friends". The flat bottom navigation bar *(Figure 1)* labels each section with familiar icons and names *(Figure 2, left)*, so students can easily predict what is behind each tab. The Join flow is kept simple and familiar: on Home, the post shows the key details and a primary action, "Join +" *(Figure 2, left)*. After joining, the confirmation panel explicitly states that the event has been added to My Schedule and offers a direct route there *(Figure 2, right)*. My Schedule then shows the same event as a card with matching image, title and date *(Figure 3, left)*, creating a strong mapping between the event in the feed and its "joined" representation in the schedule. This step-by-step alignment supports users in building a mental model of how their actions change what they see across the app *(Norman, 2013)*.

Heading: 2. Consistency, familiarity and predictability, and reducing memory load

Screen shots: *Figures 2, 3, 4, 5, 6*

Description and rationale:

The interface is deliberately consistent with common social and messaging apps to reduce how much students must remember. The same colour palette, typography and rounded card style appear on Home, Discover, My Schedule and Profile, so navigation feels predictable rather than like separate systems *(Figures 2–4, 6)*. Repeated patterns are used for interactive elements: event cards always combine an image, title, date and location in the same order, with a chevron indicating that the card is tappable *(Figure 3)*. The bottom navigation bar is fixed across almost all screens; users only need to recognise the familiar icons rather than recall where features are *(Nielsen, 1994)*. In Messages and Chat, avatars, online dots and speech bubbles closely follow other chat apps, so students can transfer existing knowledge instead of learning new conventions *(Figure 5)*.

Heading: 3. Flexibility, customisability and user control and empowerment

Screen shots: *Figures 3 and 6*

Description and rationale:

UniCircle gives students control over which events they commit to and which topics they see more of. In My Schedule, each event card includes a bin icon so that users can remove events they no longer plan to attend *(Figure 3, left)*. This supports reversibility of decisions and avoids the feeling of being "locked in" after tapping Join. At the same time, the joined status remains visible on the original post *(Figure 3, right)*, so users can confirm that their choices have taken effect. The Profile screen *(Figure 6)* allows students to customise their experience further through interest chips such as Music, Debate or Hiking. Chips have two clear states (filled versus outlined), and the subtitle explains that UniCircle will prioritise content that matches these selections. By keeping both viewing and editing of interests on one screen, the design reduces the steps needed to adjust preferences and gives users an immediate sense that they can shape the app around their own identity and changing goals *(Shneiderman et al., 2016).*

Heading: 4. Observability of system status and provision of feedback

Screen shots: *Figures 2, 3 and 5*

Description and rationale:

The prototype focuses on making system status visible so that students are not left wondering “did that work?”. When a user taps Join on the Home screen, the large green overlay with a tick and “Successfully added to My Schedule” message provides instant, highly salient feedback *(Figure 2, right)*. This is reinforced by the event card now appearing with a green “Joined” pill in both My Schedule and the original post *(Figure 3)*, giving persistent status information. In Messages and Chat, details such as the green online dot beside a friend’s name and the “Read” indicators for messages help users understand whether their friends are available and whether messages have been seen *(Figure 5)*. The chevron on the shared event card also signals that the post is interactive and will open the full event. Together these feedback mechanisms aim to reduce uncertainty and build trust that actions are being correctly recorded by the system *(Nielsen, 1994; Norman, 2013)*.

Heading: 5. Supporting social interaction

Screen shots: *Figures 4 and 5*

Description and rationale:

A core design objective was to help students meet people and attend events together, not just browse information. The Discover screen highlights trending events and presents themes such as Sports, Music and Nature *(Figure 4, left)*, encouraging students to notice activities they might discuss with friends. The Theme Events view *(Figure 4, right)* offers a focused, swipeable feed for a particular theme, mirroring familiar social media interactions and making it easy to browse options quickly. Social coordination is then supported explicitly through the Messages and Chat features *(Figure 5)*. Students can see which friends are currently active, start a conversation, and share an event directly into the chat as a card. The card can be tapped to open the full post, so friends maintain a shared reference point when deciding whether to go.

3. **References** (not included in word count)

- *Norman, D. A. (2013)* The Design of Everyday Things: Revised and Expanded Edition. *New York: Basic Books.*
- *Nielsen, J. (1994) '10 usability heuristics for user interface design', Nielsen Norman Group.*
- *Shneiderman, B., Plaisant, C., Cohen, M., Jacobs, S. (2016)* Designing the User Interface: Strategies for Effective Human-Computer Interaction *(6th ed.). Pearson.*

PART 2 - EVALUATION – USABILITY REPORT

USABILITY evaluation and user requirements for: UniCircle mobile app prototype

Date(s) Test Conducted: 9–13 December 2025

Summary

Four first-year students completed a task-based think-aloud evaluation of the UniCircle prototype. Overall they were positive about the concept but several usability issues were identified. The main problems were: weak feedback after joining an event and uncertainty about where it had gone; My Schedule cards not clearly tappable and no way to remove events; the Theme Events screen not obviously swipeable or exitable; and limited feedback in Messages/Chat (unclear if messages were read or if an event card was clickable). The prototype was updated with stronger join feedback, clearer card affordances and delete controls, visual hints in Theme Events, and richer feedback in the messaging flow (online status, read receipts, chevron on shared card).

Product details

Product name and version number (if applicable): UniCircle mobile app prototype – evaluation version v1

Elements or functions of interface evaluated: Home event join flow, My Schedule, Discover and Theme Events (music), Messages and Chat, Profile interest selection.

Intended user groups for product: Students looking to discover events and make friends at university.

Training required to use the interface: No

Purpose of product (what is it for?): To help students discover on-campus events, decide which ones to join, and attend with friends based on shared interests.

Where is product designed to be used: On students' own smartphones, typically on campus or at home.

User Test Details
Number of users tested: 4
Participant details: Four first-year students (2 female, 2 male), aged 18–19, from different degree programmes. All were regular smartphone and social-media users but had not seen UniCircle before.
Length of test session (per user): Approximately 20 minutes
Location of user test: Quiet study room on campus
Method(s) Used and why: Think-aloud usability test with task-based scenario. Chosen to reveal misunderstandings, navigation issues and mental models while participants attempted realistic event-related tasks.
Data collected: Observer notes on user actions, errors and comments; approximate task completion times; severity ratings for each incident.
User task(s) conducted: 1. From Home, find the Music Society event and join it using the Join button. 2. Use My Schedule to review joined events and open the Music Society event again. 3. From Discover, use the Music theme to explore another event. 4. From Messages, open Luna's chat, review the messages about the Music Society event, and open the event from the shared card. 5. On Profile, review and adjust your interests using the interest chips.
Brief note on severity ratings 1. ***Cosmetic problem only: need not be fixed unless extra time is available on project*** 2. ***Minor usability problem: fixing this should be given low priority*** 3. ***Major usability problem: important to fix, so should be given high priority*** 4. ***Critical issue: imperative to fix this before product can be released***

Evaluation Results

Incident Log [1]

Prototype version No: v1 (pre-fix)
Incident Description: After tapping Join on the Home screen, users were unsure whether the action had worked and where the event had been stored. The interface did not change in an obvious way, so participants did not realise they should check My Schedule.
Applied or proposed fix: The prototype was updated with a large green overlay panel containing a tick and the message "Joined – successfully added to My Schedule". This panel is tappable to open My Schedule, and a green "Joined" pill is now shown on the event both in My Schedule and on the Home post.
Severity Rating and justification: 3 – Major usability problem: affects a core task (joining events) and leaves users uncertain about system status.

Incident Log [2]

Prototype version No: v1 (pre-fix)
Incident Description: In My Schedule, participants did not realise the event cards were tappable and there was no obvious way to cancel or remove an event once joined. This reduced their sense of control over plans.
Applied or proposed fix: Event cards in My Schedule were redesigned with a clearer border and a right-facing chevron to indicate they can be tapped. A bin icon was added on each card to allow users to remove an event from their schedule. Tapping a card now opens the original post in its joined state.
Severity Rating and justification: 3 – Major usability problem: users could not easily manage or revisit joined events, which undermines the planning purpose of the app.

Incident Log [3]

Prototype version No: v1 (pre-fix)
Incident Description: On the Theme Events (music) full-screen view, some participants did not notice they could swipe for more events or how to exit the view. They tried to use the phone's back gesture instead.
Applied or proposed fix: The Theme Events view was updated with a visible swipe-hint icon to suggest vertical swiping for more events, and a clear X button in the top-right corner that returns users to the Discover screen.
Severity Rating and justification: 2 – Minor usability problem: users could still explore events but needed extra effort or relied on system back gestures.

Incident Log [4]

Prototype version No: v1 (pre-fix)
Incident Description: In Chat, participants did not always realise that the shared event card was tappable, and they were unsure whether their messages had been read.
Applied or proposed fix: A chevron indicator was added on the shared event card to show it can be tapped to open the full event post. “Read” receipts were added to sent messages.
Severity Rating and justification: 2 – Minor usability problem: does not prevent messaging but reduces confidence in social coordination around events.

Incident Log [5]

Prototype version No: v1 (pre-fix)
Incident Description: In the earlier prototype, viewing interests and editing them were on separate screens, and some participants were unsure which chips were selected or what impact they would have. This made personalisation feel like extra work and weakened the link between interests and the rest of the app.
Applied or proposed fix: The design was changed so that viewing and editing interests both happen on a single Profile screen. Interest chips now have two clear visual states (filled vs outlined), include small icons for faster recognition, and are accompanied by a subtitle explaining that UniCircle will prioritise content matching selected interests.
Severity Rating and justification: 2 – Minor usability problem: does not block use, but reduces motivation to personalise the app and understand how interests influence content.